

PORTRAYAL OF FEMALE VICTIMS OF CRIMES IN SELECTED YORÙBÁ FILMS

By

Adéfúnké Kẹ̀hìndé ADÉBÁYỌ

Linguistics and Nigerian Languages Department

University of Ilorin, Ilorin.

akadebayo24@gmail.com

adebayo.ak@unilorin.edu.ng

ABSTRACT

This paper examines the portrayal of female victims of crime in selected crime films- “Kafirantan” and “Victim”. The research interrogates how the circumstances leading to women falling victims of rape as depicted in the films. Using the tool of characterization analysis, this paper is grounded in victimology theory considering both qualitative and descriptive methods. In its findings, the paper affirms that there are women victims of rape depicted on their characterisation roles, there also exists an impact of rape on the victims. The impacts manifest in form depression, suicide, emotional and psychological trauma. Based on the findings of this paper, there is a need for exposure of the crime film production. This will inculcate in people's psyche on how to take preventive measure to avoid falling victim of rape.

Keywords: Crime, violence, Yorùbá crime films, rape, victimology theory,

Introduction

Crimes and criminal tendencies are becoming so rampant in our society that they capture the attention of scholars and filmmakers. Crime encompasses various forms and dimensions, either legal, social, or psychological in nature. Crime could be violent or non-violent, Adeyemi (2013). Violent crimes such as rape are particularly engaging the attention and interest of the filmmakers. These interests have resulted in the production and proliferation of Yorùbá crime films, particularly the ones that focus on rape victims.

A victim is a person against whom an assault or a crime known to be a violation of the law has been committed. A woman who is sexually assaulted or exploited on account of her vulnerability, such as a mental disorder or poverty, among others, is a victim. Rape as a criminal act is a crime against a woman or a man known to and recognised by law. Olújinní (2003) notes that there are incontrovertible statistics based on research that a very high number of women of all ages have continued to fall victim to violent crimes, especially rape and sexual harassment.

The proliferation of Yorùbá films with scenes of crime partly or directly targeted at female characters has been a recurring motif since such films were adaptations of myths and folktales from Yorùbá sociological settings. With the emergence of media technology and its introduction to Nigeria, a new wave of crime films with the use of lethal weapons such as pistols, machetes, bombs, etc. has become rampant. The scenes of domestic violence, such as wife battery and rape victimisation in many forms, equally assume a worrisome notoriety and dimension. This informs the assertion of Howerdy (2005) that the proliferation of crime films in

Nigeria is a breeding ground for destructive vices among youths and teenagers.

A study on female victims of crime in selected Yorùbá films cannot ignore the commission of crimes and violence in society. According to Àjàyí (2000), crime is a social problem. In his opinion, Ekpu (2001) notes that society and the media should be partners in crime detection, prevention, and reportage to achieve a crime-free society of our dreams. Various studies on crime have been unable to explain the relationship between crime, rape victims, and victimology theory.

The study aims to investigate the portrayal of female victims of crime as depicted in selected crime films. The main objective is to analyse the films in relation to victimology theory to explain how female fall victims of crime rape. The objective is to affirm that there are women victims of rape and the circumstances leading to their depiction of being victim of rape. It also interrogates the impacts suffered by the victims of rape. The paper research intends to highlight this crime so as to prevent or avoid circumstances that make a person falls victim of crime. The research will be of benefit to the family, to inculcate the victims into their children, to government in punishing the perpetrators of rape by enacting laws against rape. Scholars who have interest in diving similar research would make use of this research as a reference in his/her research.

The study aims to investigate the portrayal of female victims of crime as depicted in selected crime films. The main objective is to analyse the films in relation to victimology theory to explain how females fall victim to crime and rape. The objective is to affirm that there are women victims of rape and the circumstances leading to their depiction as victims of rape. It also interrogates the impacts suffered by the victims of rape. The paper research intends to highlight this crime so as to prevent or avoid circumstances that make a person fall victim to crime. The research will be of benefit to the family, to instill in their children the importance of respecting women, and to the government in punishing the perpetrators of rape by enacting laws against rape.

Methodology

This study employs qualitative and descriptive method. Two contemporary Yoruba crime film were selected. The sampling technique adopted was purposive sampling. The two films selected for this research are *Kafirantan* (2020) and *Victims* (2015). They are purposely selected because of their relevance to the subject matter. The films were watched and in which crime characters were identified and analysed. The content analysis provided information (data) for this research.

Theoretical Framework

The theory adopted in this study is victimology as propounded by Benjamin Mendelson (1869-1937). Models of this theory include victim precipitation, lifestyle exposure, deviant place, and routine activities, which are components of Mendelson's victimology theory.

Victimology simply implies the study of an offender and the assailed relationship and interaction before, during, and after the commission of the particular crime. Kostić (2010), one

of the proponents of Mendelson's victimology theory, asserts that victimology is primarily concerned with the subjective perception of the commission of crime, such as rape, and the effects on the victim against whom the crime has been committed. The theory emphasises that victimisation of persons and violations of inalienable human rights are involved. Some of the proponents of the theory include Wafgang, Dussich, Schneider, and Bart; all of whom unanimously opine that victims of crimes should not be seen merely as passive recipients of greed or anger in the wrong place at the wrong time but rather as crime victims are to be seen as individuals who due to some circumstances have been unjustly wronged and liable to remedies both from the justice administration sector of the society and the society at large.

Since the focus of this study is the portrayal of female victims of crime in selected Yorùbá films, we assert that the victimology theory is germane. Four theories have been developed by Von Hentig, Wethuan and Meddelsohn. The four sub-variants of victimology theory are: (i) radical theory; (ii) situation-oriented theory; (iii) feminist victimology theory, and (iv) critical victimology theory. Out of these four models of the theory of victimology, the situation-oriented theory of victimology is chosen for the analysis of this work, as it consists of four distinct elements, namely: (i) victim precipitation model; (ii) the lifestyle model; (iii) deviant place model; and (iv) routine activities model. Victim precipitation theory argues that there are victims who actually initiated the confrontation that led to their injuries and or death. It may be that the victims themselves may actually initiate either passively or actively, the criminal act that ultimately leads to injury or death. During passive precipitation, the victim unconsciously exhibits behaviours or characteristics that potentially could lead to the attack. Active precipitation is the opposite of the aforementioned described under this theory, victimisation through the threatening or provocative actions of the victims, such as nude dressing and consent of intimacy. The lifestyle exposure model argues that certain lifestyles increase one's exposure to criminal offences and increase or at times reduce the risk of victimisation. Increased risks may involve associating with other young men, and going to public places late at night, while reduced risk could be associated with staying home at night, living in a rural area, being married and staying at home, and earning more money.

Deviant place model states that greater exposure to dangerous places makes an individual more likely to become the victim of crime. According to this, model the victims do not influence the crime by actively or passively encouraging it, but rather are victimised as a result of being in "bad" or crime-prone areas. A deviant lifestyle such as alcoholism, drug consumption or drug abuse, prostitution, homosexuality and going to night clubs can potentiate high risk of victimisation. It places primary emphasis on situational elements such as the opportunity to commit crime, lack of informal control by perpetrators and their personal environment.

The Routine Activity Model argues that victimisation is dependent on the routine activities of people's daily lives, which crime perpetration exploits.

Bart's (1979) contends that victimology should be seen not only as a sub-variant of criminology but as encompassing all elements and all manners of crimes and all victims. In other words, his approach to victimology entails a critical component of crime investigation

with the basic objective of identifying profile characteristics through the analysis of crimes and victims. Thompson (2007) puts this more succinctly when he asserts that victimology is investigative to the extent that all aspects of understanding crime and the persons against whom the crimes have been committed are brought to book to face the wrath of law through proper scrutiny and dispensation of justice. He believes that Bart's (1979) approach to victimology is relevant to identification and assessment to determine criteria used to portray female victims in Yorùbá crime films under study. This is the premise upon which the adoption of the theory rests.

It is noteworthy that victimology theory originated in the 1920s in Rome where Mendelson was practising as a Lawyer then. The theory became recognised in Africa in the 1970s. That explains why scholars such as Ladner (2006) perceive victimology as a relatively new academic discipline in African literary tradition (p.7). The reason for the adoption of Mendelson's victimology theory particularly the precipitation model includes its gender encompassing and also embraces causative factors such as precipitation, routine, lifestyles and deviant. The victimology theory identifies causes of rape crime as routine, lifestyles and deviance. It emphasises that a person could be a victim of rape due to of her lifestyle like dressing mode or indulging in alcoholism or keeping late outside the home rape victim could result from routine activities like hawking. The buyers could take advantage of her by asking her to come sell what she is selling. It could result from deviant behaviour like keeping bad company or being in a place at odd times.

Victimology theory is relevant to this study because it gives room for an in-depth study of all manners of crimes and all manners of victims. It allows for a detailed assessment of the criteria used to determine female victims and their portrayal in the Yorùbá films. The theory, particularly as aforestated, is considered germane to this study because it correlates in concept and focus to the basic objective of this study, insofar as the portrayal of female victims of crimes in some selected Yorùbá films is concerned. This underscores our justification for the adoption of the situation-orientated theory in this paper and in the selection of the two crime films in which female victims are portrayed both as perpetrators and victims and victims as perpetrators.

Literature Review

Charles (2000) notes that filmmaking has become one of the highest social values and the idealised spirit of many nations. He argues that “therefore this present generation will have less excuse than most if it fails to comprehend the moral and social imperatives within the domain of filmmaking” (p. 103). Film represents the new guardian of human rights and the voice of the voiceless, the watchdog on democracy, and the mirror of the society in either realistic or fictitious form. It fashions and shapes attitudes globally about places and people and the nature of violent crime that is destroying the world. Films appeal to the audience because of their de-stress capacity to reduce tension and create awareness about the happenings in the society.

Films often explore the causes and consequences of crime and sometimes examine it within the context of specific cultural beliefs and societal structures. According to Melissa (1978), Yorùbá crime films, like other films dealing with crime, can depict rape and sexual assault. For example, the Nigerian film "October 1" focuses on rapes and murders committed by the son of the Oba of Ibàdàn, NNigeria. This is echoed by Irene (1980) when she says that Yorùbá

films can use graphic depictions of violence to create suspense, shock, or explore the darkness of human nature.

The inference of the above is understandably that film and literature will continue to enjoy the exchange of ideas both in societal consciousness and scholarly discourse. Adéyemí (2013) refers to violent crime such as rape as violence-based crime. It manifests in the form of shooting, martial arts and other forms of violent scenes. This type of film includes sensationalism, emotions and empathy of the audience.

According to Lincoln (2015), some filmmakers expose political brutality, criminality and inequality that have escalated in African countries. Filmmakers may choose to condemn or celebrate the present state of violence and man's inhumanity to man. Filmmaking is an artistic choice and a technical or civil service. It explains and associates violence with such ideologies as political violence, religious violence, terrorism, and youth militancy due to unemployment and extreme poverty.

In the view of Susan (2010), rape and sexual assault can be used as a plot device to advance the story or highlight the dangers of a particular or societal issue. An example is the movie *Omọ Olodo* (2012). Susan (1980) categorises rape into gang rape, spousal rape or marital rape and incestual rape. She opines that Nollywood has made many films that explore these categories of rape crimes. According to her, most filmmakers fail to pay attention to the presentation of the subject and end up trivialising it. Very few films between the 1990s and 2020s explored the subjects and the impact of being raped or falsely accused. *Slaves to Lust* is a classical example of incestual rape. In *Slave To Lust* (2007), a father becomes sexually attracted and obsessed with his adopted daughter, Natasha. He rapes her consistently, gets her pregnant and gets her to abort over three times. The movie *Slave to Lust* tells the story of many rape victims who are abused by their close relatives in their lives. Their stories and experiences are often not believed by the society, which thinks incestual rape is not possible. Another example of an incestual rape film is *Yet Another Day* in which Ese is abused as a child by her uncle Jonah. The movie serves as a reminder that children who are affected by rape are sometimes assaulted by a relative or someone they trust. However, Daniella (2010) submits that not all cases of rape are reported. And some reported cases of rape are true, and therefore a person can be a victim of false rape. He cites the movie *The Price* by Richard Mofe Danijo as a rape film in which Pastor Ken is wrongly and falsely accused of raping and impregnating a young woman who is a member of his church. *The Price* was one of the earlier films to promote a storyline that focused on false rape accusations and also the associated false rape victims face and have to endure.

Estelle (2013) discusses rape of minors and frowns at raping children and exposing them to sex very early in life, which may affect them in the future. She cites *The Last Girl Standing* as a classical example. In *The Last Girl Standing*, Lionel is a serial rapist who sexually abuses and rapes over 13 girls. He is an aspiring footballer who has just signed a contract with an England club when one of his victims, Thilda, reports him to her parents and the police even though her mother warned against reporting the case to the police because of the stigma it would have on the girl and the effect it would have on the relationship between her family and the rapist's family. She says that the fear of being stigmatised has some cases of rape not being

reported to the police, and the raped persons continue to carry the trauma and stigma throughout their lifetime. Victim blaming is also one of the reasons why some raped persons refuse to tell the stories of their rape experiences because the victims will be at the receiving end. The effect of this is that many female victims of rape conceal it within themselves, which allows perpetrators to go scot-free.

Sara (2015) describes some victims of rape as unfortunate victims who are raped as revenge for the offence another person has committed. The film *Òdaràn* (2017) is a classical example, in which Fatai's refusal to join a cult gang leads to the kidnap of his sister by the cultists who gang raped her. Ross (2015) dwells on marital rape and tries to criminalise it by reasonable representation of the existence of marital or spousal rape. He submits that spousal rape should be a criminal offence punishable by a jail term or fine. To him, criminalising it will curb the growing incidence of marital rape in the family. In contrast, Irene (1983) argues that marital rape should not be criminalised but legitimised, as it would lead to marriage breaks and divorce with its attendant adverse consequences on the children and the society, and that any of the spousal partners can fall victim to spousal rape. Hamsmtreeze (1953) discusses legitimising marital rape and changing social and legal attitudes about sexual assault in marriage.

Adéyémí (2013) opines that since the beginning of time, there have been numerous folktales, myths, legends and spook tales that show features of violence in Yorùbá literature. In the traditional Yorùbá society, after the day's work, various stories such as "itàn ogun" (war stories), "itàn akoni" (legends), "itàn iwásè" (myths) and "Aló onítàn" (folktales) are narrated to the children; such as the story of "Àjàntálá", who became a symbol of violence and crime, beat up a diviner with his instruments of divination and scattered the kingdom of animals. The lion ran to the wilderness, the elephant and other wild animals ran away farther, while other animals ran to the cities to become domestic animals. He became a terror until he was recalled by God. Similarly, "Ológbò Ìjàkadì" killed all the offspring of his friend and roasted them for food daily and later killed the father of the children for supper and "kòtẹ̀milòrùn" (I am not satisfied), a traditional and popular tale adapted in Fágúnwà's novels. The story captures violent crime with graphic depictions of hordes, ghosts and even the devil himself making an appearance. These stories are, however, designed and disseminated in order to frighten children and teenagers away from forbidden behaviour frowned upon by their parent

As new media are invented and imported to Nigeria, films with horror and violent episodes, which are mimicked by Nigerian filmmakers, are introduced to the Nigerian audience space. Hubert Ogunde's film "Ayé" (The World) opened the way for horror and violent film; the modal film of witchcraft soon provided the model for a long-running series that is inexhaustible. Even though the violent crime and horror scenes recorded in the film were not as we have today in home video films, the metaphysical power of the witches over the non-initiate constitutes metaphysical violent crime on the people. However, Ìṣòlá Ògúnṣọ́lá's *Àjẹ Ni Ìyá Mi* (My Mother is a Witch) which was produced by Nnebue is also a metaphysical violent encounter. Both films, that is, *Ayé* and *Àjẹ Ni Ìyá Mi* were built on impeccable cultural motifs and they exhibit considerable violence to the admiration of the audience.

Yorùbá filmmakers are members of the society. Most of them have experienced one or two

events of terrible violence, such as pouring acid on people or kidnapping scenes. The film has long been an expression reflecting public values and a community's interpretation of social processes. The Yorùbá film industry has functioned and is still functioning as a “collective diary”, expressing symbolically the people's reactions to events vital to their self-interests and existence. Crimes in Yorùbá films capture the contemporary state of political, economic, and religious as well as social crime (violence) in the society. Other cases of violence depicted are state violence, sexual violence, sexual assaults, crime and criminality, blood spills, bullying and the like (Adéyémí, 2013, p. 16).

Contemporary events of violence in Yorùbá society, as in the other parts of the world, include political violence in the form of electoral violence and religious violence. As a result of increasing youth unemployment, marginalisation, injustice and inequitable distribution of natural resources, fertile land is created for the breeding of crimes and violence. Thus, contemporary television programmes, film celluloid, home videos and movies generally celebrate violence and crimes in their productions, and people love to watch such crime films. Several Yorùbá films depict crimes by employing guns, bombs, and explosions to create spectacular actions and scenes of crime using all sorts of methods to create spectacular scenes of violent crimes through the spilling of blood (Adéyémí, 2013). The filmmakers exploit and create fictitious scenes as real to the audience so as to appeal to their sensibilities, emotions and judgement in their reaction to the crimes, especially violent crimes. The Nollywood mode of film, most of which are not real but provide the virtual world using automatic technology to make it real. Therefore, most of the crime scenes, crime perpetrators, and crime victims are fictitious and may be due to the scene and presentation by the filmmakers.

There are also revenge video films, a kind of wild justice, which can express a collective unconscious of revenge violence on someone who is felt to have never properly faced justice for his/her crimes. Examples of revenge violence films on rape abound in both secular and religious films with revenge of victims. *Ọmọ Olodo* (2012), an issue of criminal activities such as kidnapping for ritual or for money-making, kidnapping for extortion, the assassination of people, pouring of acid on people, mutilating of human bodies, sexual and domestic assaults that are regularly shown in such crime films, has become a daily occurrence in the Nigerian home video films and space. Nigerian society and the spirit of humanity are dying on a daily basis even though the objective of the films and filmmakers is to expose the perpetrators and victims of crimes to judge, label, or portray such victims of crimes (Adéyémí, 2013).

Tracing the history of Yorùbá films making, Oyèwò (2008) asserts that “the film “*Àjàní Ògún*” was the first known Yorùbá film and it was produced by Olá Balógun in the early 1970's. Qdējóbí (2004) notes that one hundred and forty-two (142) Yorùbá movies were produced between the years 1985 and 2000. However, his claim that the film titled “*Èkùn*” by Àlàdé Arómíré was the first Yorùbá celluloid movie, was countered by the duo of Barber (2002) and Ògúndèjì (2000) who both surmise that many Yorùbá movies devoid of dates of production have seen the light of day before Arómíré's “*Èkùn*” (1985).

In his contribution, Adédèjì (1981) traces the development of Yorùbá films from the era of Yorùbá theatrical performances, noting that the desire of the Yorùbá travelling theatre groups

to reach a larger audience motivated them to venture into film productions from the early 1970s. He corroborates the position of Oyèwò (2008) that the film entitled 'Àjàní Ògún' which was jointly produced and directed by Adé Afọláyan a.k.a. (Adé Love) and Ọlá Balógun a former research fellow at the Ọbáfẹmi Awólówọ University, then known as the University of Ifẹ in (1976), the first Yorùbá film in the history of the transition of Yorùbá travelling theatre groups into film making.

The inference from the above is that the Yorùbá travelling theatre groups preceding the 1970s provided the fulcrum for the popularisation of Yorùbá filmmaking/production. This means that Yorùbá travelling theatre groups are one of the pillars, if not the major pillar, holding the Yorùbá film industry today.

On the classification of Yorùbá films, Adélékè (1995) says Yorùbá films can be classified into seven categories viz (i) crime films encapsulating horror and violent scenes, (ii) love or erotic films, (iii) comic films (iv) tragic films, (v) cultural/historical films (vi) religious films and (vii) political films (pp 146-149). Adéyemí (2002) in the same vein states that Yorùbá films consist of seven categories namely (i) love films, (ii) thrillers (iii) historical films (iv) social films which often capture the socio-economic condition in the society (v) feminist films (vi) religious films and (vii) political films.

Suffice it to say that our focus in this paper is rape crime films, as the study is basically concerned with the portrayal of female victims of rape in two selected Yorùbá films. Charles (2000) notes that studies of the effects of viewing crime films have found increased acceptance of interpersonal violence and especially rape mythology" (p.62). It is noteworthy that the influx of films with scenes of crime partly or directly targeted at women has been a recurrent decimal in the movie industry in Nigeria generally and in the Yorùbá society in particular in the last couple of decades. This is probably what Howerdy (2005) alludes to when he says, "The proliferation of crime films in Nigeria provides a fertile ground for the breeding of destructive vices among youth and teenagers." Ọjẹdiran (2011) concurs as he notes that "crimes which crime films reflect do not take place in a vacuum". It is important to note that the submissions of these scholars on crime films, as far as Nigerian society is concerned, hold validity for the Yorùbá society of the Southwest of Nigeria.

The fact can hardly be denied that the social messages that many films convey often stand for a higher estimation of human personality based on the view of man as a rational creature. In other words, many people in the society including potential criminals have the tendency to internalise crime scenes they have watched in films and to go further to commit such crimes in real life.

The foregoing explains why many scholars are unanimous in their conclusions that the effects of rape crime films on the psyche of the society at large are grave. This means that crime films are a reflection of rape issues in the society, and therefore crime films can be integrated into literary discourse.

Among scholars who have critically reviewed crime films is Abéjidé (2005). In her work titled *Ìtọpinpin iwà ọ̀daràn nínú eré fílmù àgbéléwò Yorùbá*; she opines that the happenings in the Nigerian society which are often adapted to films, can be attributed to most crimes being committed in Nigerian society. She contends that most of these crimes have continued to be easily committed because the criminals live within the society. Adéyemí (2013) notes that there is apparently an uneasy relationship between Nigerian society and violence, which is traceable to viewing crime films particularly Yorùbá video films with features of ritualistic violence. He is of the opinion that Yorùbá crime films have negatively impacted the youths to be more involved in the committance of crimes rather than for the promotion of African values and patriotism as is in China, India and Japan.

In the same vein, Ọdẹjọbí (2004) has much earlier noted that the emergence of crime films and the upsurge in crime committance in the society could hardly be divorced from each other. She opines that films have their ways of registering their impacts on the consuming audience either positively or negatively.

The cumulative inference of the views of all these scholars is that the sociality of film-watching goes beyond mere leisure or entertainment. It is hardly deniable that film watching always tends to generate both productive and destructive mindsets in a sizeable number of the consuming audience. Therefore, critical reviews of films, particularly crime films, are bound to persistently command scholarly interests, especially the negative impacts of crime films on the youth and the lack of investigative apparatus to identify the real perpetrators of a crime and the justice system that leaves victims of crimes unprotected.

A synthesis of the opinions of the scholars reviewed above reveals that they failed to mention how female victims of crime are portrayed and the motif for the production of rape crime films. This is the lacuna this paper intends to fill.

Film Context and Synopsis

The two selected Yorùbá films for this study are *Káfirántàn* (2012) by Wale Ilebiyi and *Victim* (2015) by Lancelot Imasuen.

Synopsis of *Káfirántàn*

“*Káfirántàn*”, the protagonist of this film, is a brilliant young lady with splendid academic achievements. Her life begins to take a new turn when her mother—Mrs. Maxwell—cannot make it to her award ceremony at school and sends her boyfriend to take her place. Mrs Maxwell's boyfriend, a medical doctor by profession called Dr Ben, goes to pick up *Káfirántàn* at her school, and the young girl has to sleep over at his house since her mother has travelled for a business meeting. During *Káfirántàn*'s stay in Dr Ben's house, she got all sorts of sexual advances from him. She refuses and tries to escape but fails because all doors have been locked. She finds a cupboard where she hides to escape. While hiding, she seeks who to call for rescue, and having no person who could provide urgent assistance, she calls the customer care service of her phone network – Allwell Telecommunications.

The call receiver is Mrs Leslie, who was also a rape victim when she was younger, by her

stepfather, who threatens to kill her if she divulges the secret of their sexual affairs. After being raped several times, she takes the law into her own hands and kills her stepfather. However, her (Leslie's) mother, in an attempt to prevent her daughter from facing the wrath of the law, lies to the police that she murders him while raping her daughter.

Káfirántàn, also known as Kaffy, tells Leslie about her situation of being on the verge of getting raped, but Leslie breaks down into an emotional outpour instead of calling for immediate help for Káfirántàn. By the time she eventually recovers from her emotional breakdown, Ben has already found and raped Káfirántàn. She (Leslie) however, still calls Káfirántàn, seeks for her location and goes to meet her. When Leslie got to Ben's house, he was already asleep, so she sneaked in. Not long after Leslie comes to rescue Kaffy, Ben wakes and approaches Káfirántàn to rape her again. In a series of events in which they try to escape from Ben's house, Kaffy stabbed Dr Ben with scissors.

Believing that Dr. Ben has died, Leslie calls the police and falsely accuses herself of killing him in self-defence. Both Kaffy and Leslie are arrested by the police, with Ben's dad insisting that the killer of her child must be jailed. Although Ben's dad has secretly taken Ben to another hospital where he is treated and is even on the verge of sending Ben abroad to escape rape charges. He (Ben's dad) also arranges false witnesses to testify to the promiscuity of the innocent Káfirántàn to serve as evidence that his son was not responsible for raping her. However, the police investigations reveal the truth of the case and discover the game of Ben's dad. The police discovered the long-buried fact that he was also once a killer. Káfirántàn and Leslie are eventually vindicated, and Ben, his dad and his accomplices in crime are charged in court and convicted.

Victim

Yèni is the protagonist of the film. She has been exposed to a hard life from her childhood. Her father used to be a violent person who beat his wife – Yèni's mother – repeatedly at will over the most trivial of issues. In one of the beatings, Yèni's mother is eventually beaten to death by her father in her presence. But she is sternly warned by her father not to divulge the secret. Unable to keep the secret of her mother's death at the hands of her father, Yèni goes to her uncle to divulge the secret to him. Her uncle in turn tells Yèni's father what Yèni has revealed to him against Yèni's strong appeal not to. For divulging the secret, she is expelled from home and becomes a homeless wanderer. She meets Big Mamà, who tells her story about why she is homeless. Big Mamà takes her to her house, and they start living together. After some time, Big Mamà takes Yèni to Dr Kókò, who runs an illegal baby factory. Yèni is forced to sleep with three or more men daily by Dr Kókò. In the process, she (Yèni) gives birth to three children, all of whom are sold off by Dr Kókò as soon as they are born. Yèni later escapes from Dr Kókò's captivity, and yet becomes a wanderer again. In the process, she gets repeatedly raped by many men, who pretend to help her. She later kills two of such men in self-defence and becomes a criminal on the wanted list of the police.

Yèni consequently becomes a full-fledged prostitute to earn a living. While operating as a prostitute, she meets Déolú who takes her to his house for a night out. Déolú falls in love with Yèni and proposes marriage to her. Yèni after a while agrees to Déolú's marriage proposal, so they start living together after Déolú takes her to see his parents. Déolú sets Yèni up in a business

and hires a housemaid, Ìbílọlá to help her do home chores but Ìbílọlá's mother is scheming for Ìbílọlá to become Déolú's wife. With a charm she receives from her mother, Ìbílọlá tries to hypnotise Déolú into having sex with her. She undresses herself and goes to sleep beside Déolú. Yẹni enters unannounced and furiously kills Déolú and gets arrested by the police for her homicide and former crimes, including the murder of Déolú. She is also held accountable for the accident Ìbílọlá has while trying to flee from her.

All efforts made by the police interrogators to extract statements from her prove fruitless. She acts and speaks incoherently most of the time. With the intervention of Barrister Christine who is a human rights activist, Yẹni opens up, telling Barrister Christine the entire story of her life. It is Yẹni's revelation that leads to the arrest of Dr. Kókò and his accomplices in crime including Big Mamà. Dr. Kókò is tried in court and sentenced to one hundred and four years imprisonment.

The Plot constructs of the selected films of *Káfirántàn* and the *Victim*

The Plot Construct of *Káfirántàn*

The plot construct of *Káfirántàn* is rather complex. The stories told start from the middle, where Leslie reveals how she is raped as a teenager with the result that her life takes a negative twist. This scene is followed by the scenario of Dr. Ben trying to rape *Káfirántàn* with *Káfirántàn* calling Leslie on phone for assistance. Next to that, *Káfirántàn* is seen being interrogated by the police for the alleged murder of Dr. Ben. This scene is then intruded upon by the scenario of *Káfirántàn* weeping profusely for having being raped by Dr. Ben and Leslie arriving in the house of Dr. Ben belatedly. Next to that, Chief Adébáre is seen scheming to fly Dr. Ben out of the country and to ensure that *Káfirántàn* is convicted by the court for the murder of the same Dr. Ben.

Finally, Dr. Ben's father, Chief Adébáre's treachery is discovered by the police and he is promptly arrested. It is further discovered that he has been on the wanted list of the police for a long time. Mrs Maxwell, *Káfirántàn*'s mother then reveals how she solicit for the assistance of Dr. Ben her boyfriend to help her pick *Káfirántàn* from her school because she is too busy with her work to do that by herself.

The Plot Construct of *Victim*

The plot construct of victim is similarly a complex one. The film starts from the middle, where Yẹni stabs a man to death, in consequence of which policemen are drafted to the scene because the slain man is a policeman. This is followed by the scenario of Yẹni and Big Mama conversing with Big Mama leading Yẹni to her house with a promise to comfortably accommodate her. Next, Yẹni is projected soliciting for men as a prostitute by the roadside and she is picked up by Déolú who takes her to his house and proposes marriage to her. The scenario of Yẹni's captivity in a baby factory cum hospital being run by Dr. Koko, with some other young girls intrude on this. This is then followed by Yẹni's arrest and interrogation which finally leads to the introduction of the audience to Yẹni's family problem. The constant scuffle between her parent is projected cumulating in the death of Yẹni's mother. From the above analysis, it is obvious that the arrangement of the scenes featured in the film is not chronological thereby making its plot construct complex.

Analysis and Discussion

The films *Victim* and *Káfirántàn* offer compelling portrayals of female victims of crimes, rape, within a Yoruba cultural context. To address the need for a stronger integration of victimology theory depict female victims and the crimes committed against them. By connecting these portrayals to real-world issues of gender-based violence in Nigeria, the analysis highlights the films' role in reflecting societal challenges and advocating for change. Victimology theory provides a framework for analysing the portrayal of female victims in the selected films and their broader societal implications.

In *Victim*, Yẹni is portrayed as a victim of serial rape and the illegal sale of her newborn babies. Her mother is a one-time victim of battery and murder, and Yẹni becomes a secondary victim of her mother's death. Later, Yẹni accidentally kills Déolú, the only man she has affection for, positioning her as both a victim and a perpetrator of murder. Yẹni's vulnerability aligns with precipitation model of victimology and situational oriented model of victimology theory. As a young, female, and economically disadvantaged individual, she is a prime target for predatory crimes like rape. Her homelessness after her mother's death places her in a high-risk environment, making her susceptible to exploitation by Dr. Koko and Big Mama, who force her into a "baby factory" where she is raped daily by multiple men. The film illustrates the long-term effects of such victimisation, as Yẹni becomes socially withdrawn and emotionally traumatised, struggling to connect with others even after her arrest. This reflects precipitation model as a passive victim of rape. It emphasises on how personal and situational factors contribute to victimisation risk.

The film critiques societal failures in protecting vulnerable women, aligning with critical victimology. Yẹni's exploitation by Dr. Koko and Big Mama highlights how economic inequality and gender-based power dynamics facilitate victimisation. Big Mama's role as an accessory to the crimes underscores how individuals within society can perpetuate harm against marginalised groups. Furthermore, Yẹni's arrest and incarceration after killing Déolú reflect how victims can be re-victimised by the criminal justice system, which often fails to recognise their trauma or provide support. This conforms with critical victimology's concept of the "hierarchy of victimisation," where women and the poor are less likely to receive justice or societal acknowledgment

While Yẹni's actions do not actively precipitate her victimisation, her circumstances being homeless and vulnerable place her in a situation where exploitation is likely. This aligns with passive victim precipitation, where a victim's environment increases his/her risk. However, the analysis avoids victim-blaming by emphasising societal neglect and lack of support systems as key contributors to her vulnerability.

The film's portrayal of rape and its consequences mirror real-world issues in Nigeria, where gender-based violence is pervasive. According to the CLEEN Foundation, 1 in every 3 respondents identified as a victim of domestic violence, with rates increasing from 21per cent in 2011 to 30per cent in 2013 (Wikipedia, 2013). Cultural norms in some Nigerian communities, including Yoruba ones, sometimes tolerate violence against women as a form of discipline, exacerbating victimisation. "Victim" thus serves as a critique of these societal attitudes and structures.

In *Káfirántàn*, Káfirántàn and her mother, Mrs. Leslie, are both victims of rape. Mrs. Leslie kills her stepfather after his rape attempts during her teenage years, and Káfirántàn stabs Dr. Ben to death after he rapes her. Mrs. Leslie is also portrayed as a liar and murderer, as she helps her daughter avoid prosecution. Káfirántàn's and Mrs. Leslie's experiences highlight how gender and age increase victimisation risk. As a teenager, Káfirántàn is particularly vulnerable to sexual violence, especially when left in the care of Dr. Ben, whom her mother trusts. Mrs. Leslie's past as a rape victim illustrates the intergenerational nature of victimisation, where past trauma influences future actions. The film's depiction of Káfirántàn's emotional despair, contemplating suicide after her rape underscores the profound psychological impact of victimisation, aligning with positivist victimology's focus on victim characteristics and consequences.

The film critiques societal trust in authority figures like Dr. Ben, who betrays Mrs. Leslie's trust by raping her daughter. This reflects situation-oriented victimology's emphasis on how societal norms and power dynamics facilitate victimisation. Mrs. Leslie's decision to trust Dr. Ben, while well intentioned, places Káfirántàn in a vulnerable position, highlighting how societal expectations can lead to harm. The portrayal of Mrs. Leslie as a "liar and murderer" for protecting her daughter reflects societal judgment of victims who resist or retaliate, further marginalising them. This aligns with routine activities model's critique of institutional biases and societal attitudes towards victims.

Mrs. Leslie's trust in Dr. Ben can be seen as a form of passive victim precipitation, as it creates a situation where Káfirántàn's victimisation becomes possible. However, this is framed as a critique of societal structures that place undue trust in personal and authority figures, not as blame on Mrs. Leslie. Káfirántàn's act of stabbing Dr. Ben can be viewed as active resistance, challenging the notion that victims are passive and highlighting their agency in seeking justice.

It is noteworthy that the crime of rape in Nigeria has assumed a worrisome dimension, so also is the crime of accessory to the fact of crime (rape) both before and after the commission of rape and other sundry crimes normally targeted at women. A curious study of the selected films reviews that their plot construct are straightforward, relative in particular to the depiction of the female victim of crime and the nature of crimes committed against them. The crime of rape which is predatory crime commonly targeted at vulnerable girls and/or women, resonates profoundly in the selected films. For example in *Káfirántàn*, the protagonist of the film *Káfirántàn* or Kafty is portrayed as a victim of rape in the film. She is raped by Dr. Ben in whose care, her mother entrust her while travelling. Also, Mrs Leslie who comes to assist Káfirántàn to escape from the house of Dr. Ben is revealed in the film as having fallen victim to the crime of rape in the hand of her stepfather during her teenage years.

In *Victim*, Yèni is portrayed as a victim of series of rape experiences in the hands of series of men. She is forced into sex slavery in the phantom hospital of Dr. Koko, with many other young girls. There, she and her co-captives are daily raped by between four to five men. Consequently, Yèni gives birth to three children, all of whom are sold off by her captor- Dr. Kókó – before they are one week old. Yèni co-captives also undergoes similar experience.

The victimology theory which is adopted in this paper recognises rape as a predatory personal offence against women which should at all time command both the interest and proactive action of both the justice administration sector and the society at large. This is what Thompson (2007) gives affirmation to, for agreeing that victimology as a theory is always to be seen as investigative to the extent that all aspect of crimes and the persons against whom crime as been committed are properly scrutinised for proper dispensation of justice. The influence of this is that victims of crimes should at all times be liable to remedies particularly from the justice administration sector of the society. In other words, no individual who is unjustly wronged through any particular crime committed against him is left at the mercy of his offender, and no criminal who has committed crime against another person escapes appropriate justice for his crime.

It is the contention of this paper that films represent one of the vehicles through which portrayal of crimes particularly predatory crimes against females and the profile characteristics of possible offenders can be portrayed comprehensibly to members of the society. This to a considerable extent will help to arouse the interest of the appropriate segment of the society on the likely impact of such crimes both on the individuals, recipients and the psyche of the society with a view to developing acceptable framework to curtail or eradicate such crimes from the society.

On characterisation style in the selected films, any curious watcher of the film can easily discern that the characters used in the film aptly matched their role allotment in terms of age, mode of dressing and demeanours.

This shows that one of the chief motivations of the films is likely to bring to afore the fact that young and vulnerable girls are more susceptible to fallen victims of rape than their older counterparts and also that likely offenders are usually younger men with affinity of endearment to/or are close acquaintances of the potential victims.

The two selected films succinctly capture the impact of the crime of rape on the victims which include emotional trauma likely to culminate in solitariness as is the case with Yẹ̀ni in *Victim*; the loss of morals as the case is with Káfirántàn in the film *Káfirántàn*.

The film's themes resonate with Nigeria's high rates of gender-based violence. Human Rights Watch notes pervasive violence against women, including rape in internally displaced persons camps and by police, despite the Violence Against Persons Prohibition (VAPP) Act of 2015 (Human Rights Watch, 2019). Cultural beliefs that normalise violence against women as discipline further exacerbate these issues, particularly in some Yoruba communities (PMC, 2023). "Káfirántàn" thus reflects these societal challenges and critiques the lack of justice for victims.

The film reveals that Yoruba cultural norms shape representations of rape and there is need to seek redress and punish offenders as well as protecting the victims of crime. This will

serve as a deterrent for potential criminals. The films also show that family has a great role to play in inculcating cultural values in their members of the family so as to avoid falling victims of rape. Cases of rape should be reported for the authorities and security agents to apprehend the culprit and prosecute them in the court of law. Crime report should be sustained and encouraged to punish the offenders and crime perpetrators against women. The films represent the female victims through resistance, silence and retaliatory violence which made the film to have victims, victims as both victims and crime perpetrator by revenge.

Findings

The paper's findings show that Yoruba films function as a versatile site of female gendered discourse which test the usefulness and limits of victimology theory in African film analysis. It also reveals that cinema is a potent and effective tool for social awareness and advocacy against sexual violence and sexual assaults.

Conclusion

In our effort to analyse the uniqueness of the films under study in relation to rape crime, the paper enshrined in victimisation analysis examined the issue of rape and rape victims in the selected films. Focusing on victimology theory to explain the circumstances that potentiate and cause a person to fall victim of rape. It is observed that the films still fall short in certain areas, such as the representation and depiction of female victims as being responsible for their falling victim of crime rape.

The films did not cover aspects of justice, protection and support for the victims. Nonetheless, the discussion limited is hinged on victimology theory, and despite this limited scope, there are areas government and family have to pay attention to in order to prevent incidences of victimisation, particularly female victims of crime.

Film producers should gear up efforts at producing films that will aid the inculcation of good virtues and the discouragement of crime commission and criminal tendencies, particularly in the youths.

Films that will encourage scholarly research: scholars must engage more actively in research on the portrayal of violence against girls and women in media, advocating for proactive solutions. Foster community engagement as platforms for community dialogue, educating the public on victim rights and prevention strategies for gender-based violence.

REFERENCES

- Abéjídé, M.E. *Ìtọpinpin iwà ọ̀daràn nínú eré fíìmù Àgbéléwò Yorùbá ní ìlànà tíọ̀rì sọ̀sìyọ̀lọ̀jì lítírésọ̀. Unpublished M.A project, University of Ilorin. 2005.*
- Adédèjì, J.A. Alárinjọ: The traditional Yorùbá travelling theatre. In Y. Ògúnbiyí (ed). *Drama and theatre in Nigeria" A critical source book*. Great Britain: Pitman press. 1981.
- Adélékè, D.A. Audience reception of Yorùbá films: Ìbàdàn as a case study. *Unpublished Ph.D. Thesis, University of Ibàdàn, Ibàdàn. 1995.*
- Adéyemí, O. Eré fíìmù nínú ìdàgbàsókè orílẹ̀-èdè Nàìjíríà. *Yorùbá gbòde jónà ẹgbé akòmọlédè*

àtí àṣà Yorùbá Nàìjíríà, 3(2), 74-84. 2002.

- Adéyémí, O. "The Aesthetics of local violence in contemporary Yorùbá home video films: Its emergence, types and consequences in Wálé Adégbìtẹ̀, Ayò Ògúnsíjì and Taiwo Oyè (eds) *Linguistic and Globalisation of African Languages for Sustainable Development: A Festschrift in Honour of Prof. Kòlá Owólabí*. Universal Akada Books Limited. 2013.
- Àjàyí, E.P.K. Criminology: psychological and social perspectives. A paper presented at the National Judicial Institute, Lagos. 2000.
- Anomona, O. Portrayal of African women in Nollywood films over a five year period: A content analysis of traits applying the stereotype content model. *Electronic theses and dissertation*. Accessed at <http://dc.etsu.edu/etd/13166>. 2016.
- Asónibárẹ̀, A.S. Justice and jurisprudence in Nigeria. *Journal of general studies II* (ed.) 121-66-75. 2007.
- Azunwo, E, and Kalio, F. Women empowerment and domestic violence in selected Nigerian video films. *Journal of Gender and power*, vol.9, No.1. 98-123. 2018.
- Barber, K. and Ògúndíjọ, B. *Yorùbá popular theatre: three plays by the Oyin Adéjọbí Company*. United States of America: African Studies Association Press. 2002.
- Bart, C. *Principles of victimology*. Cincinnati, Ohio: Lexis Nexis Publishing. 1999.
- Brock, N. Representations of Nigerian women in Nollywood film. unpublished Ph.D. thesis submitted to the school of Postgraduate studies, Howard University. 2009.
- Charles, F. *Decoding slasher films: A comparative analysis*. Ph.D thesis City of Leeds University. 2000.
- Dussich, J.P. Victimology: past, present and future. retrieved from [https://www.unafei.or.jp/publications/pdf/RS No. 70/No.7012 vs Dissich. Pdf](https://www.unafei.or.jp/publications/pdf/RS%20No.%2070/No.7012%20vs%20Dissich.Pdf). April 5, 2019.
- Ekpu, R. *Society and media responses to crime and victims of crime*. Lagos: Newswatch Communication. 2001.
- Howerdy, T. *Films and man Psyche*. Las Vegas: Pewitt publishing company. 2005.
- Ibbi, A. Stereotype representation of women in Nigerian films. *Cinej cinema Journal*. 6(2), 49-70. 2017.
- Kostić, M. Victimology: A contemporary theoretical approach to crime and its victim. *Series: law and politics* 8(1), 65-78. Facta Universitatis. 2010.

- Ladner, B. *Victimology in focus*. London: Open house press. 2006.
- O'Brien, M. *Crimes within spousal relationship*. New York: Excalibow press. 2012.
- Ògúndèjì, P.A. *Ritual as theatre, theatre as ritual: The Nigeria example. Íṣẹ̀ṣe Monograph*. Ìbàdàn: University of Ìbàdàn. 2000.
- Ọ̀jẹ̀dìran, K. Film and censors board: The Nigerian experience. A paper presented at the theatre arts students association symposium held at the Premier Hotel, Ìbàdàn, April 2011.
- Okunna, S. Women stereotyped roles in Nigerian home video: An analysis. *Occasional paper*. Michigan University. 2002.
- Ọ̀láyínká, O. Femininity and sexual violence in the Nigerian films, “Child, Not Bride”, October 1” And “Sex for Grades”. Thesis submitted to the College of Bowling Green State University. 2021.
- Olújìnmí, B. The image of women in Yorùbá video films: an evaluation. In *Africa through the eye of the video camera*. 119-127. 2003.
- Olújìnmí, I.O. *The Portrait of the female in Yorùbá Video Films*. Ph.D. Thesis, University of Ìbàdàn, Ìbàdàn. 2004.
- Oyèwólé, B. Ipa tí àwùjọ kó lórí íṣẹ̀ lítirẹ̀ṣọ̀ Yorùbá. *Láderin Ìwé Àtìgbàdégba Egbé Akẹ̀kọ̀pọ̀ Ìjìnlẹ̀ Yorùbá*. Yunifásitì Ìlọ́rín, Ìlọ́rín. 65-77. 1992
- Oyèwọ, G.A. The making of Yorùbá video films. An actor's experience. In F. Ògúnléyẹ (Ed). *Africa through the eye of the video camera*. Manzire: Swaziland Academic Publishers. 2008.
- Schneider, H.J. Victimological developments in the world during the past three decades (1): A study of comparative victimology. In *International journal of offender therapy and comparative criminology* 45(4), pp.449-468 Sage Publications. 2001.
- Thompson, A. Short notes on victims and victimology. Ontario: Lenx-J-Paul Press Co. 2007
- (VAPPACT) The Violence against Persons Prohibition Act of 2015, p.35.
- Filmography
- (1) *Victims*, dir. Lancelot Oduwa (2015).
 - (2) *Káfirántàn*, dir. Allwell Adémólá (2020).